

Adjective order

Learner workbook

Describe an object naturally without overloading the sentence.

Understand the distinction

When several adjectives come before a noun, English tends to put opinion before more factual descriptions. A useful common order is opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose, then noun.

This is a tendency, not a requirement to use every category. Meaning, emphasis, and established phrases can affect order. Two or three well-chosen adjectives are usually clearer than a long stack. Use a dictionary or a natural example if an order feels uncertain.

Compare the patterns

OPINION + SIZE

a lovely small cafe

An opinion comes before size.

AGE + MATERIAL

an old wooden chair

Age comes before material.

COLOR + ORIGIN

a blue Italian jacket

Color normally comes before origin.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the natural order: bag / leather / small / a

- A. small a leather bag
- B. a small leather bag
- C. a leather small bag

2. Choose the natural order: wooden / old / an / table

- A. an old wooden table
- B. an wooden old table
- C. old an wooden table

3. Must every description include all adjective categories?

- A. No. Choose only useful details.
- B. No. You can only use one adjective for an object.
- C. Yes. Each object needs every adjective category.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The notebook is small and blue. Which description has the natural neutral order?

- A. I keep my notes in small a blue notebook.
- B. I keep my notes in a large red notebook.
- C. I keep my notes in a small blue notebook.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. a small leather bag

Size normally comes before material.

2. A. an old wooden table

Age normally comes before material.

3. A. No. Choose only useful details.

The order is guidance for the adjectives you need.

4. C. I keep my notes in a small blue notebook.

Size normally comes before color in this description.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-10.html